

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Hairdressing and Barbering English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Hairstylists, barbers, salon assistants, and salon reception staff.

All clients, prices, timings, products, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course is not training in cutting, shaving, chemical services, infection control, or diagnosis. Technical suitability and any health concern require the appropriately qualified professional and applicable local procedures. Sample salon policies are not universal rules.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

add-on

An extra service offered in addition to the originally selected service.

adjustment

A discussed change to a completed hairstyle to address a specific concern.

appointment slot

A period reserved in the salon schedule for a specified visit.

asymmetry

A difference in shape or apparent length between corresponding sides.

cape

A protective covering placed around a salon client's shoulders and clothing.

client record

The salon's stored information about a client's visits and relevant stated preferences.

color history

Information about previous color services and products used on a client's hair.

consultation

A discussion with a client to establish the desired hair service, preferences, and limits.

fade

A haircut with a blended transition from very short hair to longer hair above.

fringe

Hair cut to fall over the forehead; commonly called bangs in US English.

goodwill gesture

A discretionary service or benefit offered by a salon to acknowledge a problem.

handover

An exchange that passes relevant client information and outstanding tasks to another worker.

highlight

A section of hair made lighter than the surrounding hair.

itemized receipt

A receipt listing individual services or products and their separate charges.

layers

Sections cut at different lengths to create shape or movement within a hairstyle.

natural texture

The hair's usual straight, wavy, curly, or coily pattern without deliberate reshaping.

neck support

The part or accessory supporting a client's neck at a shampoo basin.

perimeter

The outer outline of a haircut, including the visible line at the ends.

rebooking

Arranging a client's next salon appointment.

reference photo

An image used to discuss a desired hairstyle, not a guarantee of an identical result.

regrowth

New hair near the scalp that differs visibly from previously colored lengths.

sensitivity

A client's reported tendency to feel discomfort or react to a product or contact.

service duration

The estimated time allocated to a particular salon service.

service menu

A salon list describing available services and their stated prices or price ranges.

service note

A factual entry describing a salon service, discussion, or unresolved request.

service review

A salon discussion examining a client's concern and the possible response.

shampoo basin

A salon sink designed for washing a client's hair.

starting price

The lowest listed price for a service whose actual charge may vary with stated factors.

taper

A gradual change from longer to shorter hair, often around the sides and neckline.

tone

The warm, cool, or neutral color character seen in hair.

waiting list

A list of clients who want to be contacted if a suitable appointment opens.

walk-in

A client seeking service without a booked appointment.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask about features, not just the whole photograph

Which part of the photo would you like to keep?

When you say short, do you mean ___?

Could you confirm whether you want ___?

A photograph contains several choices. Separate length, outline, and fringe; use an indirect question to find the feature the client means.

Word combinations in this lesson

keep the length: retain the overall length the client identifies

take off the ends: shorten the ends by an agreed amount

frame the face: arrange the front shape around the face

agree on the outline: confirm the visible shape before starting

Compare the feature that matters

In this photo, ___, whereas in that one, ___.

Both give ___, but only this image shows ___.

How much time do you normally spend on ___?

Names alone do not fix an exact length. Compare what is visible in the supplied images, then check the client's priorities without teaching a cutting method.

Word combinations in this lesson

leave weight through the top: retain fullness in the upper part of the style

soften the outline: make the visible edge look less sharply defined

wear it natural: keep the hair's usual texture in the finished look

maintain the shape: preserve the agreed style between or during appointments

Separate a desired shade from a confirmed service

The photo shows ____; it doesn't establish ____.

We still need to know ____.

Today's booking covers ____, not ____.

A target shade is a request, not evidence of suitability. Identify missing history and keep the consultation separate from a service booking.

Word combinations in this lesson

describe the regrowth: identify where the new growth is visible

review the color history: discuss previous products and services

compare color swatches: look at sample shades together

set realistic expectations: explain which result is still uncertain

Offer a choice that fits the available time

We are running ____ behind.

That would take us past ____.

Would tomorrow at ____ work instead?

State the delay and the client's departure separately. A shorter remaining window does not make the service itself shorter.

Word combinations in this lesson

run behind schedule: begin later than planned

allow time for consultation: include discussion in the booking

offer a cancellation slot: propose time freed by another client

confirm the finish-time constraint: check when a client must leave

Make it easy to report discomfort

Where does ____ feel uncomfortable?

I'll pause while we check ____.

Would you prefer to stop ____?

Invite a description rather than a yes-or-no endorsement. A comfort check is not a diagnosis or a technical treatment instruction.

Word combinations in this lesson

check the water temperature: ask how the water feels to the client

adjust the seating position: change the chair arrangement for comfort

pause the service: stop the current activity to address a concern

report discomfort promptly: tell the stylist as soon as something feels uncomfortable

Explain the full price before agreement

The price includes ___, but not ___.

Together, the total would be ___.

Would you like ___ alone or ___ as well?

Use a clear breakdown and ask for a choice. Avoid treating interest in an add-on as agreement to pay for it.

Word combinations in this lesson

quote the total: state the price for the agreed scope

check what is included: establish which services a price covers

decline an add-on: choose not to purchase an optional service

break down the charge: explain the separate items making up a total

Acknowledge the concern before proposing a remedy

You're noticing ___ on ___.

Let's look at that area together.

We haven't yet agreed on ___.

Repeat the client's observation accurately. Discuss a review before promising an adjustment, price reduction, or particular result.

Word combinations in this lesson

identify the concern: ask what specifically differs from the request

check both sides: compare the visible result from agreed viewpoints

acknowledge the mismatch: recognize a difference between expectation and result

arrange a review: organize a discussion of the concern and possible response

Keep preferences, requests, and bookings distinct

Today the client chose ___.

They asked about ___; nothing is booked yet.

Please confirm ___ directly with the client.

Use past tense for today's confirmed choices and request language for future interest. A note is not a booking or permission for another purpose.

Word combinations in this lesson

record a preference: preserve what the client actually requested

confirm the next visit: check the date, service, and person booked

pass on an open question: tell the next worker what remains unresolved

obtain photo permission: ask whether a client agrees to a specific use of an image

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Turning a reference photo into a clear request

A client shows a chin-length bob but wants to keep enough length for a low ponytail. No cut has started. The photo has a straight fringe; the client has not requested one. Clarify which features matter and confirm a collarbone-length outline.

Your photo has a shorter outline and a straight fringe, but keeping a low ponytail matters to you. Which feature of the photo do you want to keep? We can discuss a collarbone-length outline instead. Before we start, please confirm whether you want any change around your forehead.

Try it again: The client points to the fringe while saying 'this shape.' Ask whether the gesture changes the earlier preference.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Describing shape, texture, and everyday styling

A client wants less fullness at the neckline but does not want exposed skin at the sides. Photo A, labelled 'low taper,' shows visible hair covering the sides. Photo B, labelled 'skin fade,' shows exposed skin at the shortest area of the sides. The client spends five minutes styling each morning. Compare these supplied appearances, not cutting methods or guaranteed upkeep.

In these photos, the low taper keeps more visible hair at the sides, whereas the skin fade exposes skin at the shortest area. You said you want less fullness at the neckline without that exposed look. Let's discuss the taper image as a reference and check how it fits your usual five-minute routine.

Try it again: The client assumes 'low' means the same length in both photos. Clarify the actual area being compared.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Discussing color without promising a photograph

A client wants the cool tone in a photograph before Friday. Their previous home color product is unknown. Today's booking is a consultation only; suitability, service time, and cost have not been assessed.

The photograph helps us discuss the cool tone you prefer, but it doesn't establish what we can achieve by Friday. Your previous color product is still unknown. Today is a consultation; we need to review your color history before confirming a service, timing, or price.

Try it again: The client says the photograph proves it is possible in one visit. Explain the limit of that evidence.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Booking time and handling appointment changes

A haircut appointment at 2:00 is running twenty minutes late. The usual service duration is forty minutes. The client must leave by 2:45. A 10:00 appointment tomorrow is available; the stylist cannot promise a shortened service today. This salon waives the change fee when its delay causes this rescheduling.

We're twenty minutes behind, and the usual forty-minute service would take us past your 2:45 departure. I can't promise to compress it into that time. Tomorrow at ten is available. Would you prefer that appointment, or to discuss another time that gives you the full slot?

Try it again: The client offers to skip the consultation. Keep the complete appointment's timing and assessment needs clear.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Checking comfort and pausing clearly

Before a wash, a client says the neck support feels uncomfortable. Water has not started. Ask the client to describe the pressure, pause preparation, and arrange a comfort check. Do not diagnose the discomfort or prescribe a position.

Please tell me where the support feels uncomfortable before we begin. We haven't started the water, and I'll pause here while we check the arrangement with you. You don't need to put up with discomfort to keep the appointment moving. Let me know whether you want to leave the basin.

Try it again: The client apologizes for slowing the appointment. Acknowledge the concern without minimizing the discomfort.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Explaining services, prices, and product choices

The fictional menu lists a haircut at \$45 and an optional finish at \$15, with no other charges in this exercise. A client thinks \$45 includes the finish. Neither service has begun. Explain the \$60 combined total and the \$45 haircut-only choice.

The forty-five-dollar price covers the haircut; the finish is an optional fifteen-dollar addition. Together they would be sixty dollars, with no other charges. You can choose the haircut alone for forty-five. Which option would you like me to confirm before we begin?

Try it again: The client asks whether buying a product makes the finish free. No such offer exists in the supplied menu.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Responding to a concern about the result

A client says the left side looks longer. The earlier explanation promised an even outline, but the current appearance has not been reviewed together. Pause checkout, acknowledge the concern, and offer mirror review with the stylist. No correction or refund has been approved.

You were expecting an even outline, and you're noticing a longer-looking section on the left. I'm sorry this hasn't been addressed before checkout. Let's look at the area together with the stylist. We haven't agreed on an adjustment or refund yet; first we need to understand the specific concern.

Try it again: The client asks whether acknowledging the concern means the salon has approved a free adjustment.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Passing preferences to the next appointment

A client requests a future color consultation but has not booked it. Reception is taking over. Today's confirmed preferences are retained front length and no finishing spray. The client has not agreed to promotional photographs. Handover the preferences and unbooked request accurately.

Today's preferences were to retain the front length and leave out finishing spray. The client asked about a future color consultation, but no date is booked. Please offer available consultation times and confirm the choice directly. There is no agreement to promotional photography, so the visit note should not imply permission.

Try it again: The client consents to an internal reference photo but not publication. Repeat the limited permission.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Barbers, Hairstylists, and Cosmetologists

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/personal-care-and-service/barbers-hairstylists-and-cosmetologists.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Hairdressers, Hairstylists, and Cosmetologists

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/39-5012.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Hairdressing and Barbering English

Professional audience: Hairstylists, barbers, salon assistants, and salon reception staff

Scope: All clients, prices, timings, products, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course is not training in cutting, shaving, chemical services, infection control, or diagnosis. Technical suitability and any health concern require the appropriately qualified professional and applicable local procedures. Sample salon policies are not universal rules.

Lesson 01: Turning a reference photo into a clear request

Original fictional case: A client shows a chin-length bob but wants to keep enough length for a low ponytail. No cut has started. The photo has a straight fringe; the client has not requested one. Clarify which features matter and confirm a collarbone-length outline.

Language workshop: Ask about features, not just the whole photograph

Communication goal: Resolve conflicting length preferences before a haircut.

Language guidance: A photograph contains several choices. Separate length, outline, and fringe; use an indirect question to find the feature the client means.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Which part of the photo would you like to keep? / When you say short, do you mean ___? / Could you confirm whether you want ___?

Vocabulary: consultation: A discussion with a client to establish the desired hair service, preferences, and limits. / reference photo: An image used to discuss a desired hairstyle, not a guarantee of an identical result. / perimeter: The outer outline of a haircut, including the visible line at the ends. / fringe: Hair cut to fall over the forehead; commonly called bangs in US English.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: you like the photo's neat outline, not its short length or fringe; you need a low ponytail.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: The client points to the fringe while saying 'this shape.' Ask whether the gesture changes the earlier preference.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Your photo has a shorter outline and a straight fringe, but keeping a low ponytail matters to you. Which feature of the photo do you want to keep? We can discuss a collarbone-length outline instead. Before we start, please confirm whether you want any change around your forehead.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT